

From Footage to Ethogram: An Automated Vision–Language Pipeline for Quantifying Behaviour and Affective State of a Captive Octopus

Siddharth Raj*, Harald Burgsteiner†, Wolfgang Slany‡

* Research and Development, Arishna IoT Solutions, Bangalore, India

† Institute for Digital Media Education, University of Teacher Education Styria, Graz, Austria

‡ Institute of Software Engineering and Artificial Intelligence, Graz University of Technology, Graz, Austria

Abstract—Continuous camera monitoring of captive marine animals produces far more video than caretakers can review, yet most of it is used only reactively. We present an automated vision–language pipeline that converts months of continuous multi-camera aquarium footage of a single *Octopus vulgaris* into a quantified behavioural and affective-state time-series. It detects when the animal is visible (a frozen CLIP encoder with a lightweight probe under aspect-preserving preprocessing), extracts short behaviour clips gated on visibility and motion, and re-prompts a large vision–language model for a structured behavioural record per clip (behaviour class, posture, activity, location, context and body colour). Aggregating 3,083 analysed clips yields an interpretable activity budget, an exposure-normalised circadian profile with a late-afternoon activity peak, and a clear stimulus response in which human presence nearly doubles movement and raises a transparent arousal index. To make the system self-hosting we distil the teacher into small local models: a captioning student (Qwen3-VL-2B [7], QLoRA) running 4-bit on a laptop, and a single-class mask model auto-labelled by GroundingDINO and SAM2 and anchored by human-verified masks. On a leak-free human-labelled test (122 frames from five held-out source videos) that model reaches 0.64 mean / 0.72 median IoU with 1.1% body-area error, and its mask area doubles as the pipeline’s presence gate, which works only because the student is trained with empty-mask negatives. On top of the masks we extract an *anatomical skeleton*—mantle, head and up to eight arm splines—scored on a frozen benchmark by arm-tip F1 against protrusions of the human mask (0.54), a metric adopted only after “arms per frame” proved gameable and the replacement’s own ground truth proved wrong. Its occlusion-honest arm kinematics independently separate the VLM-derived behaviour classes on 146 clips from 66 source videos, aggregated to one value per (video, class) before testing (median arm-tip speed 53 px s^{-1} resting vs. 141 reaching out of water; Kruskal–Wallis $p=3.5 \times 10^{-6}$, $\epsilon^2=0.22$, and still significant in scale-invariant body-lengths per second): a cross-validation of two signal paths that share no components. We frame results as arousal and behavioural state rather than emotion, report the limitations and the measured negative results honestly, and position the work as the profiling layer complementary to real-time single-behaviour response systems.

Index Terms—Computer Vision; Vision–Language Models; Behaviour Analysis; Marine Animal Welfare; Model Distillation; Edge AI; Cephalopods

I. INTRODUCTION

Aquarium and controlled-habitat monitoring increasingly relies on continuous camera coverage, but the resulting video vastly exceeds what caretakers can review. Most footage is

therefore consulted only reactively, and the record of an animal’s day-to-day behaviour is left unquantified. For welfare-oriented husbandry the more valuable question is longitudinal: *how does this animal spend its time, and how does it respond to its environment?*

Octopuses make this both important and hard. They are highly intelligent, behaviourally complex invertebrates whose welfare is a growing concern, yet their non-rigid bodies, rapid posture changes, active camouflage, frequent denning, and the reflections and floating debris of tank environments defeat naive visual monitoring [1]. A companion line of work from our consortium targets a single, actionable behaviour—a “protest” limb gesture used to request tank lighting—and actuates the lights; that system is reactive and behaviour-specific by design.

This paper addresses the complementary problem: *understanding the whole behavioural repertoire over time*. We present an automated pipeline that turns continuous multi-camera footage of one captive *O. vulgaris* (“Nity”) into a structured behavioural and affective-state time-series, together with the small local models needed to run it cheaply and offline. Our contributions are:

- 1) An end-to-end pipeline from raw footage to a per-clip *structured behavioural record*, using a large vision–language model (VLM) as a zero-shot behavioural annotator with snap-to-list validation.
- 2) An aggregate behavioural analysis of the animal over several months: an interpretable activity budget, an exposure-normalised circadian profile, and a quantified stimulus response, framed as arousal / behavioural state.
- 3) Teacher→student distillation into deployable local models—a 4-bit captioning student that runs on a laptop, and a single-class octopus segmentation model auto-labelled by GroundingDINO+SAM2, anchored by human-verified masks, and evaluated leak-free on a held-out human-labelled test (0.64 mean / 0.72 median IoU, 1.1% body-area error — one model, one test set, with the split re-derived to prove the holdout was never trained on).
- 4) An anatomical skeleton and kinematics layer on the masks: per-frame mantle/head/arm graphs scored by arm-tip F1

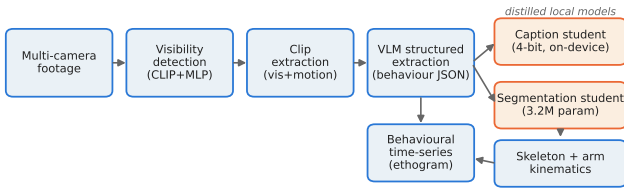


Fig. 1. Footage-to-ethogram pipeline (the four stages of Sec. III): visibility detection → clip extraction → VLM structured behavioural extraction → distillation into local caption and segmentation students.

on a frozen benchmark, with the arm-selection gates reported as an explicit precision–recall frontier rather than a single tuned point; occlusion-honest tracking; and per-arm kinematics that separate the VLM behaviour classes with video-level statistics on 146 clips from 66 recordings—a cross-validation of two unrelated signal paths.

- 5) A frozen benchmark suite (segmentation, skeleton, tracking; one runner, tagged results, video-level splits) and an honest account of the methodology around it, including measured negative results: a train–test leakage we caught and corrected, a headline metric retired because a genuine improvement made it worse, a metric ground truth we had to validate and fix, and several plausible improvements that failed under the fixed benchmark.

II. RELATED WORK

Cephalopod behaviour and welfare. Interest in octopus cognition and welfare has grown alongside their inclusion in animal-welfare frameworks. Prior consortium work introduced a framework for decoding inter-species communication with octopodes and a real-time detector for a light-request behaviour that actuates the habitat [1]; our work is the profiling counterpart to that response system.

Foundation models as annotators. General-purpose VLMs describe and classify images zero-shot, and open-vocabulary detectors and promptable segmenters (GroundingDINO [3], SAM/SAM2 [4]) label without task-specific supervision. We use these as *teachers*, distilling their labels into small students [5]. CLIP [2] provides the frozen features for our presence detector; the deployed segmenter uses an LR-ASPP/MobileNetV3 head [6].

III. SYSTEM AND METHODS

The tank is observed by a multi-camera rig (6 IP cameras, 4K, infrared and colour night vision) with a manually selected region of interest around the den per camera; the same installation supports the companion response system.

A. Visibility Detection

A frozen CLIP ViT-B/32 encoder feeds a small multi-layer-perceptron probe (512→256→64→2) classifying *octopus-visible* vs. *hidden*. The single most important design choice

was preprocessing: CLIP’s default centre-crop discards 33–44% of a 16:9 frame, and *aspect-ratio mismatch*—not backbone capacity—was the root cause of poor field performance. Aspect-preserving letterbox padding plus $\sim 1.7k$ mined reflection/infrared-noise hard negatives gave a probe reaching 96.8% on our internal detection test set.

B. Clip Extraction

Per second of source video we compute the probe’s visibility probability and an absolute changed-pixel motion fraction (with the burned-in timestamp region masked so the ticking clock is not counted as motion), and keep a non-overlapping 20s window when the octopus is visible for a majority of it and mean motion exceeds a threshold. The *absolute* fraction is deliberate: per-video normalised motion promotes static scenes (a flickering lamp) to “motion”.

C. Structured Behavioural Extraction

Rather than treating a caption as the end product, we treat it as one field of a *structured behavioural record*. Per clip we select the clearest frames (contrast-enhanced for the dim infrared footage, scored by the visibility probe) and prompt a large VLM (Qwen3-VL-235B [7], via API) for a JSON record: {present, behaviour (7-class ethogram), posture, activity level, location, context, body colour, colour/texture change, confidence}. Each field is validated by snapping to an allowed value list; colour fields are gated per clip, so infrared/greyscale clips (detected by low BGR channel divergence) are told to leave colour *uncertain*. The run over 3,205 clips cost $\approx \$2.22$ ($\sim \$0.0006/\text{clip}$). We note—and exploit—that the VLM is a far stronger presence filter than the detector: on one batch it judged 63% of detector-“verified” clips to contain no octopus, almost all reflections.

D. Distillation to Local Models

The expensive foundation models are used only as *offline teachers*; nothing large is deployed. Their outputs become training data for small students, so the running system is self-hosting and needs no GPU server or paid API. We apply the recipe twice—VLM captions into a compact captioning model, GroundingDINO+SAM2 masks into a single-class segmentation model (Sec. V)—each kept as small as the task allows so continuous in-situ inference is feasible on commodity hardware.

E. Diverse-Footage Harvesting

Early models were trained on footage from a single week, the binding generalisation limit. We therefore built a streaming harvester that crawls the archive and *probes* a handful of frames per candidate video before committing to a full scan, skipping empty “den” videos cheaply. Because the server imposes a low aggregate bandwidth cap (measured $\sim 5\text{ MB/s}$, parallel connections yielding only $1.6\times$), it runs as a single CPU worker that streams rather than bulk-downloads, keeping a coverage ledger so skipped footage can be revisited—expanding coverage from 7 to >100 distinct days.

TABLE I

FROZEN BENCHMARK SUITE, DEPLOYED CONFIGURATION (OCTO_SEG_THIN768_LRASPP.PT). ALL SPLITS ARE BY SOURCE VIDEO; THE SEGMENTATION TEST VIDEOS ARE EXCLUDED FROM EVERY TRAINING SOURCE. MASK IOU AND PRESENCE AUC COME FROM THE SAME MODEL ON THE SAME TEST SET. TIP-F1 SCORES ARM RECOVERY AGAINST THE HUMAN MASK’S PROTRUSIONS, SO BOTH MISSED AND SPURIOUS ARMS ARE PENALISED; ARM COUNT IS DESCRIPTIVE ONLY.

Metric	Value
SEG-TEST — 122 human-mask frames, 5 held-out videos	
mask IoU (mean / median)	0.641 / 0.719
body-area error	1.05%
presence AUC (vs 19 empty)	0.794
SKEL-50 — 50 frozen frames	
arm-tip F1	0.539
tip precision / recall	0.722 / 0.502
arms per frame (descriptive)	3.68

F. Evaluation Protocol: a Frozen Benchmark Suite

A pipeline this long makes it easy to accumulate numbers each measured on a slightly different set, so we froze three benchmarks behind a single runner writing tagged results, making every improvement claim a before/after on the same data. *SEG-TEST*: 122 human-labelled mask frames plus 19 empty-mask negatives, from five source videos excluded from every training source; mask IoU, body-area error, presence AUC. *SKEL-50*: 50 frozen frames over 20 source videos, each with image, human mask and model mask; arm-tip F1. *TRACK-10*: 10 frozen clips spanning all six behaviour classes, three cameras and three dates; teleport rate, occluded fraction, coverage. Two rules hold throughout: splits are by *source video*, never by frame—frames from one recording are near-duplicates and we shipped that bug once (Sec. V)—and the frozen lists are never regenerated to suit a result (Table I).

We also verify “held out” rather than assert it. All five *SEG-TEST* videos appear in the deployed model’s *dataset* manifest, which lists every labelled pair, but a forced-holdout flag keeps them out of training: re-deriving the split from the manifest, source filter and seeded shuffle reproduces the logged partition exactly (3,450 train / 1,693 validation frames), with no holdout video in training. The audit also exposed—and we fixed—a logging bug printing wrong video counts for a correct split, which is what a leak looks like at a glance.

IV. BEHAVIOURAL AND AFFECTIVE-STATE ANALYSIS

Aggregating the 3,083 present clips (joined to absolute clock time) yields an interpretable behavioural profile. We report **arousal and behavioural state**, not emotion; the transparent arousal index is $0.6 \cdot \text{activity} + 0.4 \cdot \text{posture-spread}$, with static body colour a secondary channel on colour cameras only.

Activity budget. Exploration/manipulation 41%, resting 33%, human/enrichment interaction 14%, reaching out of water 9%, crawling 2%, swimming/jetting 1% (Fig. 2a).

Circadian structure. Normalising present-clip counts by all extracted windows per hour (an exposure correction) reveals

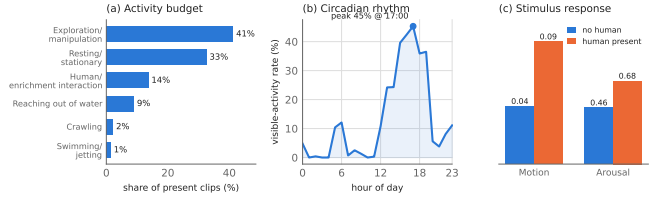


Fig. 2. Aggregate behaviour from the structured records: (a) activity budget; (b) exposure-normalised circadian visible-activity rate; (c) motion and arousal with vs. without human presence.

a strong diel pattern: visible activity is $\sim 1\text{--}5\%$ overnight and rises to a $\sim 45\%$ peak at 17:00 with a 13:00–19:00 plateau, plus a dawn bump at 05:00–06:00.

Stimulus response. With vs. without a human present, mean motion nearly doubles ($0.045 \rightarrow 0.095$) and the arousal index rises ($0.46 \rightarrow 0.68$). On colour cameras the dark red-brown body colour is most common at baseline ($\sim 16\%$) and less so during human interaction ($\sim 6\%$). We regard such *contrasts* as the robust findings; absolute levels depend on the upstream presence gate and will shift as the detector improves.

V. LOCAL MODELS

A. Captioning Student

We distil the teacher’s one-sentence descriptions into Qwen3-VL-2B [7] using QLoRA (rank 16). On a 50-clip held-out split, embedding similarity to the teacher improves from 0.702 (base) to 0.834 and ROUGE-L from 0.269 to 0.455. Quantised to 4-bit with MLX, the student is ~ 1.7 GB and captions a clip in ~ 3 s on a 16 GB laptop with no GPU.

B. Segmentation Student

Following Sec. III-D we target the *smallest* model that yields usable masks: one foreground class at low resolution, with GroundingDINO (box) + SAM2 (mask) as an off-line auto-labeller, never deployed. The most-confident frame seeds SAM2 video propagation, and largest-blob plus area-continuity cleanup remove transient errors—correcting the two systematic failures of per-frame prompting (infrared bright-tool bleed, colour background bleed) and rejecting the reflection camera by low seed confidence. Auto-labelling produced 4,412 (image, mask) pairs, from which we distilled students across a size sweep (a compact U-Net at several widths, an LR-ASPP head); we retain the smallest clearing our quality bar, an LR-ASPP student of 3.2 M parameters.

Training configuration. 768² input, 60 epochs, batch 8, Adam at 3×10^{-4} (cosine), best-validation-IoU checkpoint; loss = focal Tversky ($\alpha=0.2, \beta=0.8$, so false negatives—missed thin arms—dominate) + 0.5 BCE; strong augmentation applied to image and mask in lock-step (flip, affine, $\pm 25\%$ brightness-contrast, sensor noise); 5,143 pairs from 183 source videos, split by source video. Code, frozen benchmark definitions and evaluation scripts will be released with the paper.

Used as a *presence* signal, the mask area attacks the pipeline’s dominant false-positive source—tank-glass reflections, on which the visibility probe fires confidently—and

works only because the student sees empty-mask negatives: a positives-only student was a coin flip (AUC 0.50). On SEG-TEST the deployed model reaches presence AUC 0.794 (122 present vs. 19 empty frames), the same model and test set as the IoU below. We report it descriptively with no confidence interval: those 19 negatives come from only *two* recordings, 18 from a single one, so this is effectively a single-video estimate and must not be ordered against estimates from many recordings; enlarging that set is the most valuable repair to this benchmark. An earlier negatives-trained variant, scored separately on a reflection-heavy set from the tank-glass camera, reached AUC 0.86 overall and 0.99 against reflections (0% false positives at area 0.01, 88% present-recall)—a different model on a different set, not merged with the above.

Raising mask quality: what worked and what did not. Early students plateaued near 0.47 IoU across model sizes, architectures and augmentation. (i) *Video diversity* (sources expanded from 62 to 176 distinct videos via the harvest of Sec. III-E) helped modestly but robustly (0.468 $\rightarrow$ 0.494 on a harder, diverse-date validation). (ii) *Cleaner teacher labels did not help*: re-labelling with larger teachers (GroundingDINO-base, SAM2-large) left held-out IoU flat (0.494 $\rightarrow$ 0.506); the earlier signal suggesting label noise was the ceiling turned out to be *train-test leakage* between two label sources, caught, corrected with a hard video-level holdout, and re-measured. (iii) *Human-verified masks*: a click-to-SAM2 tool (one click seeds SAM2, the human corrects) produced 412 positive and 87 empty-mask labels; human labels alone underperformed the blend (0.505 vs. 0.608)—at this scale volume beats purity—but they give the project its first human-verified held-out test set. (iv) The decisive levers came from inspecting failures there: the octopus occupies a median 2.5% of the frame, so at the original 256^2 input its arms are 1–2 pixels wide, and the symmetric Dice+BCE loss did not penalise under-segmentation. Training at 512^2 with a focal Tversky loss ($\beta > \alpha$, penalising false negatives) lifts 0.466 to 0.608 mean / 0.666 median IoU; 768^2 with $\beta=0.8$, improving thin-structure recall, gives the deployed model: 0.641 **mean** / 0.719 **median IoU**, 1.05% body-area error on the same 122 frames (Table I). It also scores above the 512^2 variant on presence (0.794 vs. 0.718 AUC)—indicative only, as both share the same 19 single-recording-dominated negatives—so one checkpoint serves the presence gate and the skeleton of Sec. VI. The residual IoU gap is dominated by thin arm boundaries; the *area* signal the behavioural analysis consumes is accurate to $\sim 1\%$.

A negative that needed a control: test-time temporal fusion. Because the model fails by mis-*locating* a correctly-sized blob, the obvious remedy is temporal evidence—and the deployed skeleton path already thresholds an exponentially-smoothed map, while every IoU above is single-frame. We fused each frame with its neighbours at $t \pm 1, \pm 2$ (per-pixel median) three ways: exponential smoothing, DIS-optical-flow warping before the median, and—as a control—the same median with *no* warping. A fixed threshold would be unfair, since

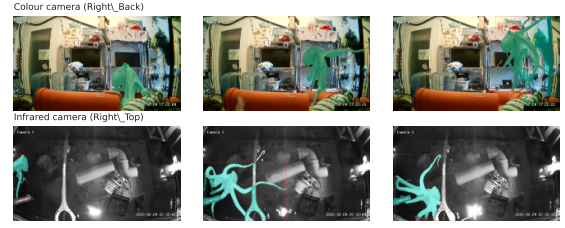


Fig. 3. Auto-labelling teacher (GroundingDINO+SAM2) masks tracked across a clip on a colour camera (top) and an infrared camera (bottom). SAM2 video propagation with largest-blob and area-continuity cleanup yields the temporally consistent masks used to train the student.

a median over neighbours systematically shrinks the probability map, so we swept it and scored every variant at its own best operating point. *The negative holds*: the best arm (exponential smoothing) reaches 0.5866 IoU against 0.6552 single-frame (-0.069). Test-time fusion does not repair mislocalisation; it blurs boundaries on a fast-deforming animal. The control then changed our reading of *why* fused masks gate presence better: unwarped averaging beats optical flow on *both* metrics (IoU 0.5527 vs. 0.5109; presence AUC 0.9629 vs. 0.9521), so averaging supplies the benefit and motion compensation subtracts from it—dense flow is unreliable on a low-texture, deforming body in dim infrared. Without the control we would have published “optical-flow fusion improves the presence gate”: true in isolation, wrong about the mechanism. We do not headline the fusion presence gain, since it rests on the same 19 two-recording empty frames.

VI. ANATOMICAL SKELETON AND ARM KINEMATICS

The masks enable a more structured representation: a per-frame *anatomical skeleton*—mantle centre, head node and up to eight arm splines with base/mid/tip landmarks—from which per-arm kinematics (tip speed, posture spread) are derived. Extraction is classical: topology-preserving thinning, Dijkstra arm-path selection from an anatomical root, and mask-constrained splines.

A frozen benchmark and measured fixes. All skeleton work is evaluated on SKEL-50 (Sec. III-F). The headline metric is *arm-tip F1* against the protrusions of the *human* mask, matched greedily one-to-one within 5% of the image diagonal, so a duplicate arm cannot match the same protrusion twice and both missed and spurious arms are penalised. Decomposing the loss per stage (silhouette $\rightarrow$ thinning $\rightarrow$ selection) located the errors and produced the fixes we ship: relaxed arm-selection floors that had discarded short, curled arms; mask preparation whose blur threshold erased thin arms; an anatomically constrained head; the higher-resolution student of Sec. V; and, offline, SAM2 refinement of the student’s mask (the student *locates*, SAM2 *sharpens*). The head rule—a neck constriction between mantle and arm crown—replaced a widest-second-blob heuristic plausible in only 9% of frames; it reached 96% on introduction and reads 80% under the current stricter gates, but “plausible” is a loose criterion that we are replacing with pixel error against human clicks on the eyes. Two plausible

TABLE II

ARM-SELECTION GATE FRONTIER ON SKEL-50 (50 FROZEN FRAMES, CORRECTED TIP GROUND TRUTH). GATES ARE (UNIQUE-SUFFIX SCALE, UNIQUE-SUFFIX FRACTION, TIP-THINNESS RATIO); P/R ARE AGAINST HUMAN-MASK PROTRUSIONS AND ARMS PER FRAME IS DESCRIPTIVE ONLY. *Caveat*: THE DUPLICATE RATE USES THE SAME CRITERION THE GATES ENFORCE, SO GATED ROWS ARE 0 BY CONSTRUCTION.

Gate setting	P	R	F1	Dup.	Arms
Gates off	0.659	0.562	0.565	0.076	4.64
(1.0, 0.15, 0.85)	0.673	0.535	0.550	0.038	4.28
(1.5, 0.20, 1.00) shipped	0.722	0.502	0.539	0.000	3.68
(2.0, 0.30, 0.55) 1st attempt	0.760	0.468	0.520	0.000	3.24

improvements measured as nulls: hysteresis skeletonisation of the segmentation *probability field* (the missing arms are not sub-threshold—the student genuinely does not see them) and a zoom-in second segmentation pass (crops are out-of-distribution). On the ceiling: the same protrusion detector on the *human* masks yields a mean of 5.7 (median 6, max 8) protrusions per frame—a 2-D silhouette hides arms folded under the body—so even perfect recall here is recall against a subset of the eight arms.

Choosing an operating point, not a number. Arm selection carries two “anti-mess” gates—unique-suffix and tip-thinness—added after inspection showed duplicate late-forking arms and stubs ending inside the body. They are a straight precision-for-recall trade, so we report the whole frontier (Table II), not just the shipped point. We ship an F1-suboptimal setting because downstream kinematics consume arm *identities* over time, where a duplicated arm is worse than a missing one.

Two lessons about metrics. First, *arm count is not a score*: when the gates removed roughly 1.3 duplicate or tangled arms per frame—a visibly cleaner output—the count we tracked fell $4.80 \rightarrow 3.48$, a 27% “regression” produced by a genuine improvement. Precision alone is equally gameable (emit one obvious arm), hence F1 against human-mask protrusions. Second, *the replacement metric’s own ground truth was wrong*: at default sensitivity our protrusion detector counted contour bumps as separate arms—mean 9.7, up to 14 per human mask—so the eight-arm cap bound in 80% of frames and recall was scored against partly fictional arms. Requiring peaks $\geq 10\%$ of the contour apart moved the shipped configuration’s tip-F1 from 0.441 to 0.539 (precision $0.685 \rightarrow 0.722$, recall $0.380 \rightarrow 0.502$). The error was concentrated in recall, so every pre-fix F1 is incomparable with post-fix ones and every ranking had to be re-measured (Table II). Validate a new metric’s *own* ground truth before trusting rankings it produces.

Occlusion-honest tracking and kinematics. Across a clip, per-frame skeletons are linked by seeding from the best-resolved frame and propagating bidirectionally (median arms maintained per clip rise from 2.2 to 5.8), with a per-node optical-flow motion prior. Every node carries a state—*detected*, *fitted* or *occluded*—and motion is computed *only* from evidence-backed samples: instrumenting this revealed that 42% of arm samples in naive tracking were evidence-free

holds whose apparent smoothness masked fabricated stillness. A global tracklet-association alternative measured worse and is reported as a negative.

Cross-validation of the two signal paths. Merging per-clip kinematics into the structured records gives an independent check on the VLM labels, tested on a behaviour-stratified sample of 146 clips from 66 source videos (~ 25 clips per class, at most two per video) and aggregated to one value per (video, class) before any test, since clips from one recording are not independent. State-gated arm-tip speed separates the classes in the direction ethology expects (Fig. 5): median 53 px s^{-1} for resting, rising through human interaction, crawling, swimming and exploration to 141 for reaching out of water (Kruskal–Wallis $H=33.2$, $p=3.5 \times 10^{-6}$, $\epsilon^2=0.22$ over 132 video–class units; all five resting-vs-class contrasts significant after Holm correction). Raw pixel speed confounds motion with apparent size, so every test is repeated on speed divided by arm spread—body-lengths per second—and the separation survives ($H=21.4$, $p=6.8 \times 10^{-4}$, $\epsilon^2=0.13$, all five contrasts still significant). The normalised view also corrects the raw one: reaching is fastest in pixels but only third in body-lengths per second, being performed with an extended body, while swimming and crawling rise. Since the two pathways share no components beyond the raw video, their agreement indicates both track real behaviour rather than each other’s artefacts—though it shows the kinematics follow the labels, not that the labels are correct, which the blocked reliability benchmark below must settle. An earlier $n=40$ -clip version, pooled at clip level, gave the same ordering with more extreme endpoints (63 to 159 px s^{-1}); the powered estimate is the more conservative one. Speeds are camera-relative pixels; metric calibration is future work.

Relevance to the OCEANS community. The work targets intelligent sensing and longitudinal behavioural analysis for controlled marine habitats, and emphasises *edge deployability*: the students run offline on commodity hardware, so in-situ monitoring needs no cloud. Where the companion system acts on one behaviour in real time, this pipeline supplies the baseline against which such events are interpreted.

VII. LIMITATIONS AND ONGOING WORK

We are deliberate about what is not yet established.

- **Human-verified test sets exist only for segmentation** (499 human masks; five source videos excluded from *all* training sources). Detection and captioning stay on internal splits, so we make no comparative claims there.
- **The VLM behaviour labels are not yet validated.** Every aggregate result is grouped by labels the structured extractor produced, and their reliability is unmeasured; a frozen 250-clip re-annotation benchmark (stratified over behaviours, cameras and not-present clips, with a disjoint frame sample to expose frame-selection sensitivity) is implemented but blocked on an expired API credential. It measures the extractor’s *consistency*, not accuracy against a human ethologist—the larger open item.



Fig. 4. Qualitative example from the frozen benchmark (arm splines coloured, tips marked), shipped post-gate configuration. Left: skeleton on the segmentation student’s mask (3 arms). Right: the same frame after offline SAM2 refinement, which sharpens the silhouette and recovers 5 arms; the rest are folded against the body, not separable in a 2-D silhouette.

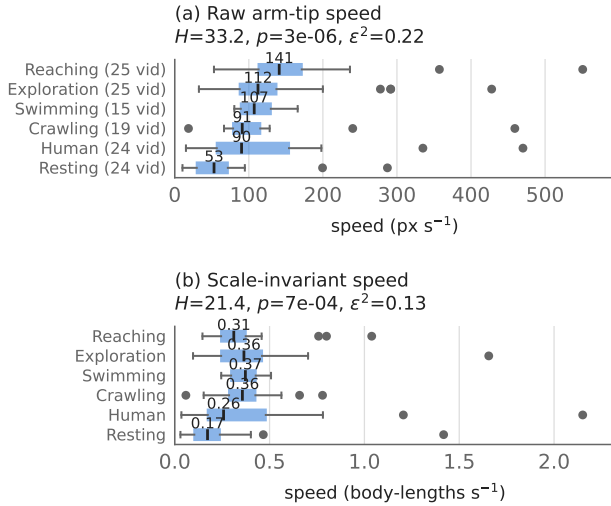


Fig. 5. State-gated arm-tip speed by VLM-assigned behaviour class (146 clips / 66 source videos, ≤ 2 per video). Each box summarises the per-video medians—the independent unit, since clip-level pooling would be pseudo-replication; dots are videos beyond the whiskers. (b) divides speed by arm spread, removing the apparent-size confound; both panels keep the class order of (a), so the rank change is visible: reaching is fastest in raw pixels but third in body-lengths per second, being performed with an extended body.

- **Leakage is easy and we hit it once.** Two label sources sharing source videos silently placed test videos in training; an apparent $0.49 \rightarrow 0.70$ improvement evaporated under a hard video-level holdout. All results here post-date that correction and the current holdout was re-verified (Sec. III-F).
- **The presence benchmark is under-powered.** Its 19 empty-tank negatives come from two recordings, so we report it descriptively; a detector-independent, multi-recording empty-frame set is built and is the next measurement. Reflection negatives for the deployed model are staged but not yet human-verified, so we claim no number for them. Absolute behavioural rates depend on this gate; we report contrasts, robust to constant gate bias.
- **Mask errors are localisation errors, and the cheap temporal fix fails.** Body area is accurate to $\sim 1\%$ while IoU is 0.64: the mask is the right size in the wrong place. Test-time fusion does not repair this even at each variant’s best threshold; a temporally *trained* student is untested.
- **Context label is coarse.** “Enrichment interaction” fires

whenever a permanent tank object is visible ($\sim 66\%$ of clips); the clean stimulus contrast is human-present vs. absent.

- **Skeleton and kinematics.** Arm recovery is silhouette-limited: even human masks expose only 5.7 arm protrusions per frame and the model’s masks cost more, so tip recall stands at 0.50. Kinematics cover a 146-clip stratified sample, with swimming/jetting on the fewest recordings (15), and infrared cameras are not covered by the colour-trained segmenter. A static-feature behaviour classifier failed (below the majority baseline), confirming that behaviour classification needs temporal features rather than more labels—which the kinematics layer supplies.

Ongoing work: extending the kinematics to the full corpus and re-basing the presence gate on multi-recording negatives; distilling the structured extractor into the local 2-B student (JSON targets rather than a sentence); and, to pass the silhouette ceiling, a learned keypoint model on RGB appearance rather than masks.

VIII. CONCLUSION

We presented an automated vision–language pipeline that converts continuous octopus footage into a quantified behavioural and affective-state time-series and distils its large teachers into local models that run offline. It surfaces an interpretable activity budget, a circadian rhythm and a measurable stimulus response; the segmentation student—evaluated leak-free on a human-verified test—supplies the presence signal and the masks for an anatomical skeleton whose occlusion-honest kinematics separate the language-model behaviour classes under video-level statistics. Reported with its negative results and leakage lessons, it offers a practical, welfare-oriented layer for longitudinal behavioural understanding in controlled marine habitats.

ETHICAL STATEMENT AND DATA AVAILABILITY

The work was conducted in a private aquarium, with only sub-threshold interactions w.r.t. EC directive 2010/63/EU of several caretakers with a single *O. vulgaris* (supplier: Flying Sharks, Portugal). Husbandry and enrichment followed best practice under FELASA guidelines. Video data are available from the last author.

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